A New Home

By Dori Samadzai Bonner

DORI: **(Pg 174-180)** I grew up in Afghanistan during the Russian occupation, and as a child I remember my dad being gone a lot. The subject of my dad's whereabouts was taboo; my mom told us never to ask about him, so we never did.

Growing up during the war was very difficult. We had bomb explosions and missile attacks on a daily basis. By the time I was ten, these explosions were getting closer and closer to the city of Kabul, where we used to live. In fact, there's a distinct whistling sound that the missile makes right before hitting its target *(whistling sound . . . explosion)*.

INTRODUCTION

Poet Warsan Shire gave voice to refugees world-wide with her words . . . "No one leaves home unless home is the mouth of a shark. You only run for the border when you see the whole city running as well. . . No one would leave home unless home told you your survival is more important. . . No one leaves home until home is a sweaty voice in your ear saying – leave, run away from me now. I don't know what I've become, but I know that anywhere is safer than here."

Fleeing the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, one family seeks asylum in the US.
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DORI: There was a rumor about a regime change, which was devastating news for my dad, who was a high-ranking officer working for the current regime. Historically, the newer regime takes over by violently dismantling the old regime. My parents were desperate to get out of the country, After a daring escape in the middle of the night, my parents, my brother and I migrated to the US on forged papers and asked for political asylum. This meant that we could stay here temporarily while they reviewed our case. They gave us a work permit, driver's license, and Social Security card.

So, all of us started working. We had family in California who helped us get settled.

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Fast-forward five years, I'm at my job at the Men's Wearhouse, and my dad calls me.

DAD: *(excitement in his voice)* You need to come home right away, because there's a letter from immigration.

DORI: I speak the best English in my household, so he wanted me to come home and translate. I rush home, and I find my dad in his security-guard uniform. My mom and my brother are home, 'cause my dad called them, too. I read the highlights really quickly. It says our appointment has been moved up to next week, and that we need to bring all of our legal documents and our family photos.

This is it. This is the appointment that we've been waiting for.

The day of our appointment, we drive to downtown Los Angeles, and go into a big government building. An immigration officer guides us into this room. We felt like we were in the wrong place. The people sitting there were visibly upset. Some of them were crying.

OFFICER: Just sit down until you hear your last name.

DORI: Can you tell me how long this appointment might take? My dad needs to get back to work.

OFFICER: Your dad will get back to work, all right, just not in this country.

DORI: And my heart just dropped. Going back was not an option, because we're now considered traitors, and would be arrested as soon as we got off the plane.

I sat down and hesitantly told my dad this, and my dad lost all the color in his face.

After about forty-five minutes, a man walks in and says our last name, and all four of us get up. A judge is sitting there. It's an older gentleman, and he looks really intense. He won't even smile.

The judge turns his attention to my dad. After some basic questions, he asks my dad if he has a translator.

DAD: My daughter will translate for us.

DORI: I was pretty intimidated.

JUDGE: Young lady, whatever I say to you, you translate exactly what I say, nothing more,

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nothing less. And whatever your dad says, you tell me exactly what he says, nothing more, nothing less.

DORI: I agree. He asks my dad questions, really demeaning questions, like, "Do I understand correctly that you came here on forged papers?" And my dad starts to say, "Well, yes, but . . . " And then my dad goes into this long explanation. But the judge cuts my dad off and says, **"I** just want to hear yes or no. I don't care about the explanation." And so the conversation goes on like this, back and forth, and it's not going well at all.

JUDGE: You know, we here in the United States do not give citizenship to people that break the law. We can't, and I won't.

DORI: And as soon as I translate this to my dad, I put my head down, and I just start praying. *(Clasp hands and pray)* When I open my eyes, I see my dad rising out of his seat. He starts unbuckling his belt, at which point I'm thinking he's completely losing his mind. I'm not sure what he's doing.

But he lifts up his shirt on the right side and, in his native language, looks at the judge and says, "This is what the communists did to me." He's pointing to a five-inch knife scar.

Then he pushes down his pants in the back and turns around a little bit, and again says, "This is what the communists did to me," pointing at three gunshot wounds.

And he takes off his shoes, and takes off his socks, and says, "This is what the communists did to me." He's pointing at his toenails, which they had tried to pull out with pliers.

I remember thinking, ***I know I'm hearing what I'm hearing.*** But everything wasn't registering, because I am translating these horrible things and also learning for the first time about my dad's whereabouts. All those times years ago that I didn't know where he was, wondering if he cared about me, he was in prison being tortured. And in that moment, I have never felt more sorrow.

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DAD: *(with great pride)* It's easy for you to judge me. You sit in that seat and you wear that robe. But if you came on this side, and you looked at me -- one man to another -- you will see that everything I did, I did to save my children. I had no other choice.

And you might deny it right now, but had it been you, I know you would have done the same thing. If you have to show the American public that you didn't take it easy on us, I understand. *(crying)* Send me back. I volunteer. But please let my children stay. Please give my children a new home.

DORI: The judge leaves. We're on a break. [He] comes back after an hour, and as soon as he enters the room, I notice he doesn't have his robe on. He goes up to his chamber and grabs something and starts walking back towards us. We're pretty nervous. The entire time his eyes are on my dad. He goes past me and stops right next to my dad.

JUDGE: Mr. Samadzai, let me see your hand.

DORI: My dad shows him his hand, and the judge puts a stamp in my dad's hand and says, "Mr. Samadzai, I would like you to be the one to stamp your children's papers." Together they stamp our papers: **ASYLUM GRANTED**

He then flips the page to my parents' papers and stamps it with the same stamp.

He looks down at my dad, puts his hand on his shoulder, and says, "Welcome to America."

It took us eighteen years from the day that we arrived here for me to be granted an American citizenship. On January 29, 2009, I was sworn in as an American citizen, and I pledged allegiance to my new homeland.

And it is through my children, that I will make sure that this gratitude that overflows in my heart every single day will continue to live on long after I am gone.

May God always bless our America.

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AWARD HISTORY

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